

Instructor Guide

Lesson Metadata

- **Path:** Digital Independence Path
- **Course:** 17 — Skills That Pay
- **Lesson:** 6 — Marketplace Models: What Changes at Different Ages?
- **Age band:** 15–18
- **Format:** Live, instructor-led (synchronous virtual classroom)
- **Duration:** 60 minutes
- **Tools referenced in-session:** Google Docs, Canva, Notion, Email, Spreadsheets
- **Lesson type:** Case-study / analytical. This is **not** a signup walkthrough. No student creates or is instructed to create an account on any platform named in this lesson during class.

Overview

Students already know (from earlier lessons in Course 17) how to describe a skill, price a service, and write a simple pitch. This lesson steps back and asks a structural question: **why do freelance and creative marketplaces treat users differently depending on age, and what does that mean for a 15–18 year old thinking about earning online?**

Students will compare four real platforms — Fiverr, Upwork, Etsy, and Gumroad — purely as case studies in how marketplaces design account and age rules. The goal is comprehension and judgment, not enrollment. By the end, students should be able to explain *why* these rules exist (not just recite them), know that the specifics can and do change, and know where they would need to verify current policy before ever acting on it.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

1. Explain at least two legal/structural reasons marketplaces set age and account-ownership rules (contract capacity, payment/liability, child-safety compliance).
2. Compare Fiverr, Upwork, Etsy, and Gumroad's stated age/account models as of the lesson date, and correctly identify which require a guardian-owned account for minors.
3. State clearly, in their own words, why misrepresenting age to a platform is not something Lumexa teaches or endorses, and why it carries real risk.

4. Identify the step they would need to take (e.g., "talk to a parent/guardian," "wait until 18," "check current ToS") if they wanted to use one of these models responsibly.
5. Recognize that these rules are policy, not law fixed in stone — they change, and must be verified before acting.

Prep (Before Class)

- **Verify current policy first.** Platform age/account rules change without notice. Before teaching this lesson, the instructor must re-check the current Terms of Service / Trust & Safety pages for Fiverr, Upwork, Etsy, and Gumroad (or their most recent cached summaries provided by Lumexa curriculum ops) and update the comparison table below if anything has shifted. Do not teach last term's numbers from memory.
- Confirm the comparison table slide/doc is loaded in Google Docs or Canva and is editable live if a correction is needed.
- Have the Notion lesson board open with the four platform columns pre-built (see Teaching Sequence, Segment 2).
- Have a blank spreadsheet template ready for the small-group comparison activity.
- Review the "Common Misconceptions" section below so you can respond quickly and firmly if a student raises the "I'll just lie about my age" idea — this must be addressed directly, not dodged.
- Note: this lesson does not require or permit live sign-up demonstrations. Do not screen-share an actual account-creation flow on any named platform.

Talking Points: Why Do These Age Rules Exist?

Use these to frame Segment 1. Do not just present the rules — explain the *reasoning*, so students can generalize the pattern to platforms not covered today.

1. **Contract-capacity law.** In most jurisdictions, minors have limited legal capacity to enter binding contracts. A marketplace's terms of service is a contract. Many platforms handle this by requiring a parent/guardian to be the account holder and the contracting party for a minor, or by simply restricting the platform to adults. This is a legal-liability design choice, not an arbitrary preference.
2. **Payment and financial liability.** Payouts often involve tax reporting, banking relationships, and payment-processor rules (e.g., needing a bank account or tax ID in most cases held by an adult). A platform that pays out real money has to know who is legally responsible for that money.
3. **Child-safety and platform-safety compliance.** Marketplaces that allow open messaging between strangers (buyers and sellers) carry real child-safety considerations. Some platforms restrict minors more heavily for this reason, or require guardian oversight of the account and its communications.
4. **Jurisdiction differences.** "Age of majority" (the age at which someone is legally an adult) is 18 in most places students will encounter, but not universally — this is why a platform like Upwork phrases its rule as "18, or the age of majority in your jurisdiction" rather than a flat number.
5. **These are business policies layered on top of law, and they change.** Companies adjust their trust-and-safety policies as regulations, litigation, and business needs evolve. A rule taught today may be updated by the time a

student is old enough to act on it.

Comparison Table (Demo Reference — Verify Before Teaching)

Present this as a **case study artifact**, e.g., built live in Canva or Google Docs with students following along in Notion. Frame it explicitly: *"We are studying how these four companies structure access by age — not signing up for anything today."*

Platform	Stated model (verify current ToS before class)	Minimum age to hold own account	Under that age?
Fiverr	Allows users aged 13–17 to sell/buy only through an account owned and managed by a parent or legal guardian; full adult terms apply at the age of majority.	Adult terms at age of majority (commonly 18)	Only via parent/guardian-owned account, 13–17
Upwork	Requires users to be 18, or the age of majority in their jurisdiction if different, to use the platform at all.	18 (or local age of majority)	Not permitted to use the platform
Etsy	Allows users aged 13–17 to have a shop only through an account owned and operated by a parent or legal guardian.	Adult terms at age of majority	Only via parent/guardian-owned account, 13–17
Gumroad	Age, guardian-involvement, and payout eligibility rules vary by country and individual circumstance (e.g., local financial/tax rules for minors); no single global number applies.	Varies by country	Must check current, country-specific policy

Instructor note to say out loud, every time this table is shown: *"This table is a snapshot for classroom discussion. These companies can and do change their policies. If any of you ever consider actually using one of these platforms, the correct first step is to look up that platform's current Terms of Service yourself, and talk with a parent or guardian — not to rely on what we studied in class today."*

Teaching Sequence

0:00–0:05 — Opening & framing (5 min) Pose the question: "If you wanted to sell a service or a design online right now, what do you think would stop you, or slow you down?" Take 2–3 quick answers. Frame the lesson: today is about understanding *why* marketplaces set rules by age — not about picking one to join today.

0:05–0:15 — Why age rules exist (10 min) Deliver the "Talking Points" above. Use the Google Doc to jot the three reasons (contract capacity, payment/liability, child-safety) as a running list students can see. Ask: "Which of these three reasons do you think matters most for a site where strangers pay each other money?"

0:15–0:30 — Case study walkthrough (15 min) Build the Comparison Table live (Canva or Google Docs, mirrored in Notion). Go platform by platform: - Fiverr and Etsy together (parent/guardian-owned account model, 13–17) - Upwork (flat 18+/age-of-majority model) - Gumroad (variable, country-dependent model) For each, ask: "Why might this company have chosen this specific model?" Connect back to the talking points.

0:30–0:40 — Small group activity (10 min) Break into groups of 3–4 (or pairs, depending on class size). Each group gets a spreadsheet with the four platforms as rows and is asked to fill in: "What would a 16-year-old need in

order to use this responsibly?" and "What changes at 18?" This reuses the Worksheet document. Groups do NOT visit any platform website during this activity — it is reasoning from the case-study material only.

0:40–0:50 — Discussion questions (10 min) Bring the class back together. Use the Discussion Questions below. Prioritize the misconception check ("what if I just said I was older?") even if time is tight — do not skip it.

0:50–0:57 — Reflection & submission instructions (7 min) Students open the Student Lesson doc's reflection prompts and begin writing (can finish as homework). Explain submission: reflections and completed worksheets are submitted via the class Notion board or emailed to the instructor, per standard course workflow.

0:57–1:00 — Lesson close (3 min) Recap the three objectives hit today. Restate the core rule clearly one final time (see Lesson Close below).

Discussion Questions

1. Fiverr and Etsy both use a "parent/guardian-owned account" model for 13–17 year olds, while Upwork does not allow anyone under 18 (or the local age of majority) at all. Why might a company choose one model over the other?
2. Gumroad's answer is "it depends on your country." Why would a company's rules need to differ by country instead of being one global rule?
3. If you were 16 and genuinely wanted to sell something online through one of these models, what is the *first* real-world step you'd need to take before doing anything on a website?
4. What's the difference between a rule existing because of *company policy* versus a rule existing because of *law*? Does that difference matter to you as a user?
5. Why do you think platforms that involve strangers messaging each other (versus, say, a school project tool) tend to have stricter age rules?

Common Misconceptions (Address Directly)

- **"I can just say I'm 18 / lie about my age to get around it."** Shut this down explicitly and immediately, every time it comes up. Say clearly: *"Lumexa does not teach, suggest, or endorse misrepresenting your age to any platform, ever. It's a violation of that platform's terms, it can get an account permanently banned along with any money in it, and in some cases it can have legal consequences beyond just losing an account. We're studying these rules to understand how business and law work, not to find a workaround."* Do not let this pass as a joke — treat it as a real misconception worth correcting on the spot.
- **"These rules never change, so I can just remember today's table."** Correct directly: *"These are company policies, and companies update their trust-and-safety and legal terms regularly — sometimes because of new laws, sometimes because of business decisions. Anything you learn today has a shelf life. Before you ever act on this information for real, check the platform's current policy yourself."*
- **"A parent/guardian-owned account means the parent does all the work."** Clarify: it typically means the account is legally held and controlled by the adult, with the minor's work happening under that account — arrangements for who actually does the tasks are a family/practical matter, not something this lesson prescribes.

- **"If Upwork says 18+, that means literally every country's minimum is 18."** Clarify the "or age of majority in your jurisdiction" phrasing — most students will encounter 18, but the platform's own language accounts for jurisdictions where it differs.

Anticipated Student Difficulties & Troubleshooting

- **Difficulty:** Students conflate "platform policy" with "the law." *Fix:* Use the contract-capacity talking point again — the law sets a backdrop (limited contract capacity for minors), and the platform's policy is its own business choice for handling that backdrop.
- **Difficulty:** Students want to actually visit the platforms during class "just to look." *Fix:* Redirect firmly — the case-study material provided is sufficient for the lesson; visiting live sites is unnecessary and outside the lesson's scope. Reiterate this is a comprehension lesson, not a signup task.
- **Difficulty:** Students fixate on "which platform should I use" as if picking a favorite team. *Fix:* Reframe to the actual objective — understanding *why* the models differ, not ranking or endorsing platforms.
- **Difficulty:** A student states or implies they (or a friend) already misrepresented their age on one of these platforms. *Fix:* Do not lecture the individual student publicly. Acknowledge neutrally ("okay, thanks for sharing"), and use it as a moment to restate the general classroom rule about what Lumexa does and doesn't teach, without singling the student out. If there is a serious safety concern, follow standard Lumexa escalation procedure to a program coordinator.

How to Review Student Work

- **Worksheet:** Check that each platform's row correctly identifies the parent/guardian-owned model (Fiverr, Etsy), the 18+/age-of-majority model (Upwork), and the "varies by country" model (Gumroad). The "what changes at 18" column should reflect that adult/full terms generally apply at majority.
- **Reflection prompts:** Look for genuine reasoning about the student's own situation, not platform trivia. A strong reflection references at least one of the underlying reasons (legal, financial, safety) rather than just restating the table.
- **Red flag to address immediately, privately:** any submitted work that describes or plans a way to misrepresent age or bypass a guardian-account requirement. This should be treated as a teaching moment (redirect to the no-bypass principle) and, if it suggests real intent, escalated per Lumexa's student-safety procedure — not simply marked wrong and left alone.

Lesson Close

End with this framing, spoken clearly to the whole class:

"Today wasn't about picking a platform to join. It was about understanding that marketplaces build different rules for different ages because of real legal, financial, and safety reasons — and those rules are policies that change over time, not facts to memorize forever. If any of you are ever seriously considering using a platform like these, the responsible path is: check that platform's current terms yourself, and talk to a parent or guardian first. Lumexa will

never teach you to get around an age rule or misrepresent your age — that's not a shortcut, it's a risk to your money, your account, and potentially more. Next lesson, we'll look at [next Course 17 topic]."